

Jargon Buster



Bleed: The region of the page that is beyond the marked area within which printing usually occurs.

Buffer: Memory within the printer that stores data from the computer until it can be printed. Buffers vary in size, with the average for laser printers being around 8 MB. Greater the buffer, the better the handling of large print jobs.

CMYK: CMYK stands for Cyan, Magenta, Yellow and black and is a shorter version of the industry standard term, 'four colour process printing'. By combining these colours, a printer is able to print all possible colours. Most full-colour prints that you see are created by this method (magazines, brochures, retail packaging, etc).

Colour Balance: This term refers to the correct combination of Cyan, Magenta and Yellow required to exactly reproduce the colours of the original scene or object

Dpi: Short for Dots Per Inch, this is a measure of the vertical resolution of the printer. Higher dpi values (1200 and above) produce sharper printouts, while lower dpi values (300 and below) produce images that have noticeable dots in them.

Duplexing: This refers to the ability of a printer to print on both sides of a paper. This is a very handy way of saving on paper. However, this option is neither cheap, nor common. An alternative is to use manual duplexing. In this method, you print the odd or even-numbered pages first and once the job is completed, you manually flip the pages over and the printer prints on the other side.

Interface: This is the type of connection that the printer has with the computer. Older printers use the parallel interface, but this has become obsolete. The latest printers use either USB or FireWire connections as their interface.

LASER: An acronym for Light Amplification by Stimulated Emission of Radiation, this is a process that produces a very intense light beam. In a laser printer, this beam is used to fuse the toner, or ink, onto the paper.

PostScript: This is a computer language or protocol used for communication between the computer and the printer. The computer sends information about the pages to be printed by the printer in PostScript format.

1/2 page Ver. AD

How They Fared

Laser printers are capable of churning out large volumes of printouts with impressive quality. These workhorses have long been the mainstay of huge corporations because of their ability to deliver quality and speed, and now, with prices having gone down, they are a fairly viable option for use at home and in a small office.

Features

When it comes to features in laser printers, the equation is simple: the greater the number of features it supports for easier paper handling and usage, the higher the points it gets. This includes a paper in and out tray, an LCD display, a USB port along with the mandatory parallel interface. It should also support as high a resolution as possible within the price range and preferably, it should have visual indicators for paper empty, paper jam and so on, which would facilitate easier usage of the printer. Lets take a look at which of the printers did well in these areas.